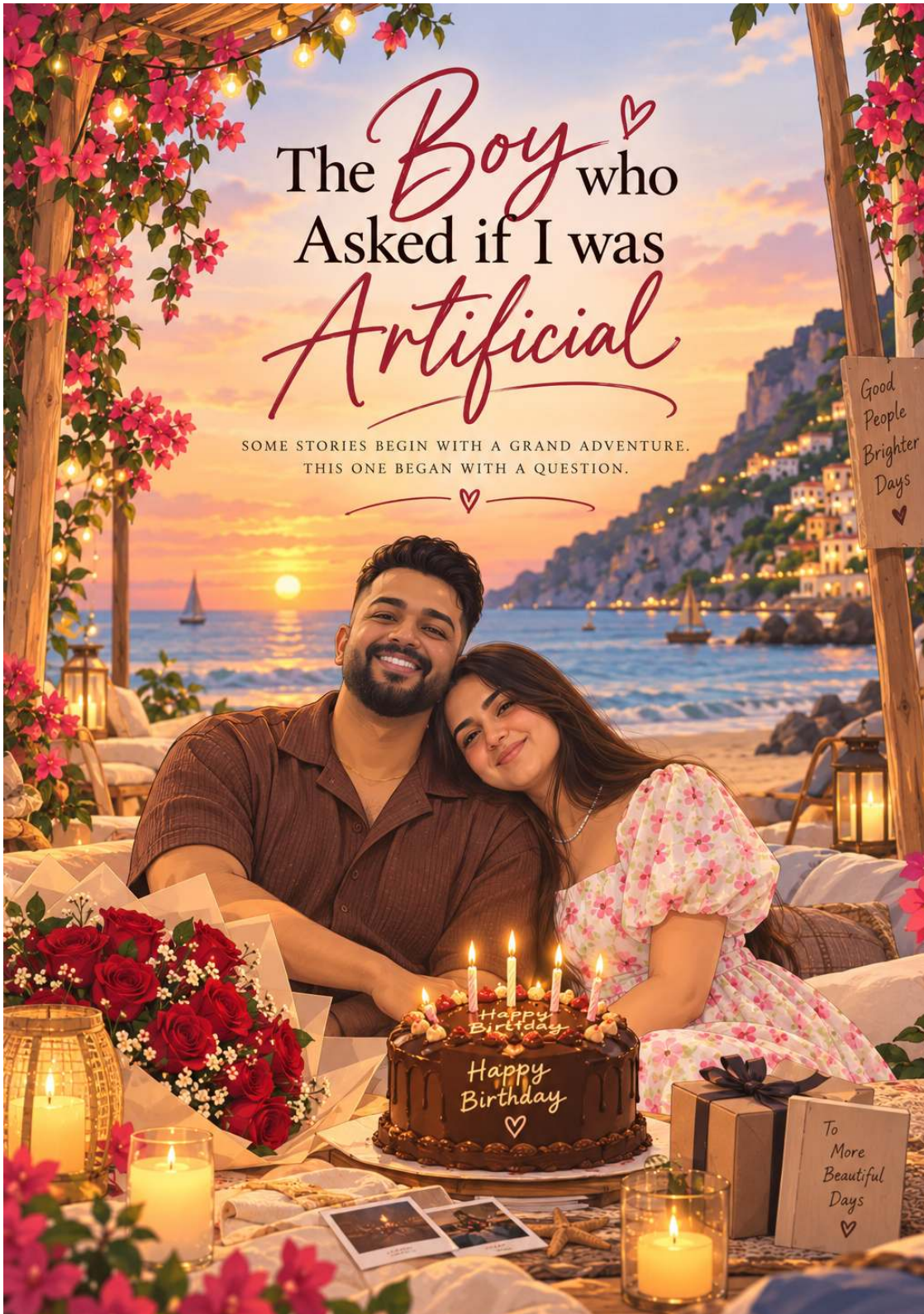


The *Boy* [♥] who Asked if I was *Artificial*

SOME STORIES BEGIN WITH A GRAND ADVENTURE.
THIS ONE BEGAN WITH A QUESTION.



Good
People
Brighter
Days
♥

To
More
Beautiful
Days
♥



Once upon a time, in a city that was always awake, there lived a boy who seemed to have everything figured out.

He lived on his own, built his days around work, and carried himself with the quiet confidence of someone who had learned how to handle life without asking it to be easy. He worked for a huge multinational company, and at work he was known as the kind of man who could walk into a room and make people straighten their backs. He was sharp, serious when he needed to be, and not particularly interested in wasting time.

There was, however, something rather inconvenient about him.

He was very charming.

Warm chocolate-coloured skin, deep eyes that seemed to notice more than they revealed, perfectly kept hair and a neatly trimmed beard gave him the kind of presence that was difficult to ignore. Nothing about him looks accidental. Even the little details seem to fall into place without effort.

He walks into the office carrying his laptop bag, sleeves folded neatly halfway up his arms, just enough to reveal the tattoo on his hand. His shoes are polished, his clothes look effortlessly put together, and somehow even an ordinary walk through the office seems to have a certain presence to it. And before anyone even looks up to see who has arrived, there is a scent that gives him away — clean and refreshing, like a cool sea breeze arriving on a hot evening, sweeping away the tiredness of the day and leaving behind the quiet feeling that perhaps the evening could last a little longer.

But that is only the version the world knows.



There was another side of him, one that appeared when the office doors closed behind him and he returned to the little world he had built for himself.

At home, the formal shirts and polished shoes gave way to shorts and a sando. The serious man from the office somehow disappeared, and in his place was someone who could dance on his bed for no particular reason, laugh at the silliest things and behave like a child who had just been given an entire evening with nothing important to do.

Whenever visiting home, he was simply himself — sitting with his family and his dogs, whom he calls Janu and Bisku, laughing with them, listening to them, and enjoying the comfort of being around the ones who had known him long before the world knew his job title. He would jokingly tell anyone who listened that he had personally given birth to his Janu and Bisku, and that the evidence was still there — the stitches from their birth. Bisku, apparently, had been an easy delivery. Janu, on the other hand, had made sure she earned every single stitch.

He has worked hard to build this life, and there is a quiet pride in the way he carries it. He knows how to take care of himself, make his own decisions and stand firmly on his own feet.

But perhaps there is one thing he hasn't quite figured out yet.

Love.





What is love, really? He thinks.

Is it the kind of thing people put on social media, carefully choosing the right photograph and the right caption? Or something that looks perfect all the time, as though people never have bad days, misunderstandings or inconvenient moments?

If love is real, it has to be something much more meaningful than that.

It is wanting to be with the person simply to sit beside them, have a cup of tea together, and listen to how their day went.

It is the feeling of walking into a crowded room and still finding that one face before noticing anyone else.

It is wanting good things for another person, even when there is nothing in it for yourself.

It is remembering the small things.

It is being able to laugh together until your stomach hurts and then, on another day, sit quietly without needing to fill the silence.

It is showing up.

Again and again.



One evening, after another long day at work, while walking home, he stopped at a little printing shop to get a few copies of his identification documents that his friend had asked for to book flight tickets.

The shopkeeper took his documents, disappeared behind the counter, and returned a few minutes later with several printed copies neatly placed inside an envelope.

"Here you go."

The boy took the envelope, thanked him and continued home.

He had barely settled in when his phone rang. It was his friend.

"Hey, did you get the Xerox copies I asked for?"

"Yes. Come and take them."

A little while later—

Knock. Knock. Someone was at the door.

"Coming..."

"Oh, hey buddy! Here. Take it. I have no idea why you needed so many copies anyway."

"Wait... Man, what is this? I didn't ask for your girlfriend's pictures. I need IDs. I don't have time for jokes."

"Girlfriend? I don't have a girlfriend, dude!"



His friend raised an eyebrow.

"Then who is she? Your imaginary girlfriend?"

"What are you talking about?"

He took the envelope.

"Yeak, looks imaginary only... How can someone look this perfect? Must be edited. Anyway, the shopkeeper made a mistake. I'll go tomorrow and get the right ones."

"Okay, but please do it in the morning. I don't have time."

"Sure, buddy. Good night!"

His friend left, and the door closed behind him.

But something about the pictures was still bothering him.

He sat on his teal-green couch, still wearing his office clothes and shoes, with the envelope in his hand, studying the backgrounds. The lighting. Her hair. The way everything seemed to fit together so perfectly that it almost felt unnatural.





The next morning, he walked back into the printing shop.

Before he could say anything, someone walked in and went straight to the counter.

"I came yesterday to get my pictures printed. You gave me these instead. I'm not paying for this again. Keep these and please print my pictures again."

The boy turned and looked at her.

Slowly, he held up the envelope.

"I think this might be yours."

Her eyes fell on the envelope and she looked at him, curious.

"Btw you did a great job editing pictures but they look a little artificial."

She looked at him, surprised.

"Sorry, WHAT? What's wrong with my pictures?"

"Nothing. I mean... your hair, your skin, the clothes, the backgrounds. Everything looks so perfect."

She took the envelope from him, shook her head with a small smile, and walked out of the shop.



PRINTING

PHOTOGRAPHS
DOCUMENTS
ID PRINTS
LAMINATION
BINDING

PRINT
SCAN
COPY



"Hey! Hi."

She looked at him, recognising him almost immediately.

"I am really sorry about that day. Let me make it up to you. Maybe I could take you out for coffee?"

"I don't like coffee."

"Phew. Thank God. I don't like coffee either."

"I like tea."

"You mean chai?"

"Can I take you out for a chai then? I know a great place nearby that makes great chai."

"Now? On New Year's Eve?"

"Sounds like a great way to welcome a new year."

She smiled.

"Okay. Let's go."

And just like that, they left the noise of the party behind and walked towards the chai shop.

Neither of them knew it then, but this was never meant to be just a random encounter.

This is all these 2 people ever needed in life to feel complete, happy, and loved.





It wasn't love at first sight. They didn't even know each other. And yet, there was something strangely familiar about it all, something that made them feel as though they had known each other much longer than they actually had. Calls that were supposed to last five minutes somehow turned into hours, starting with something ordinary and ending with neither of them wanting to say goodnight.

She began to discover the man behind the first impression. The serious one was still there, but with her, he was different. He was playful. He could turn the most ordinary conversation into something ridiculous, laugh at the silliest things, spend an entire evening being completely unserious and then, five minutes later, have a thoughtful conversation about life.

He noticed when something was wrong, even when she said nothing. He remembered the little things. He made time to call even when he was busy, and if he couldn't, he would let her know instead of leaving her wondering. He carried the bags without being asked, opened the door, pulled out the chair, and brought flowers just because he wanted to see her smile.

And then there was the part she never expected. The man she had once thought wouldn't even be interested in her now couldn't wait to talk to her. He didn't care about sending double messages or think twice before calling her ten times a day. He simply wanted to hear her voice, talk about anything and everything, and shower her with all the affection he had for her. He became the person she could laugh with when everything was good, complain to when everything was annoying, and sit quietly beside when there was nothing to say. Sometimes he was a boyfriend, sometimes a partner, sometimes a therapist, and sometimes a brother who knew exactly how to annoy her. And sometimes, he was simply the person on the other end of the phone who could make an ordinary day feel a little less ordinary.

And slowly, she realised something. The man she had first met by accident was someone she could imagine building an entire life with. Not a perfect life. A real one. One with laughter and arguments, tired evenings and lazy mornings, groceries to buy and dishes to wash. One where they would grow together. They found their home. They had each other. <3





26 September 2026

And then comes the day she had been waiting for — HIS BIRTHDAY!

She gives him a good morning kiss and whispers into his ear,

"Happy birthday kuchupuchu."

"Is that my birthday present?"

"That's just the beginning."

"Would you like to have some tea and butter toast?"

"Yes, come. I will help you in the kitchen."

In the kitchen, she toasts the bread while he makes the chai and spreads butter on the toast. Somehow, he wakes up feeling so refreshed and full of energy.

She sends him off a little earlier than usual, pretending she simply doesn't want him to be late.

The moment he leaves, she gets to her actual work — setting everything up for his birthday. She gets some flour, eggs, chocolate and everything she needs to make his cake herself, then puts the mixture into a heart-shaped mould. Chocolate cake is her favourite, and somehow, her favourite things have become his favourites too.

She takes out the dress he once gifted her, then decorates the house with fresh flowers and little DIY garlands and builds a small floor tent with a comfortable mattress, pillows and cute lights for their movie date that night.

By the time he is due home, everything is ready. Popcorn. Pizza. Cake. And her.



The door opens.

"Baby, I am home!"

"Oh my God, what is all this! Babe, where are you?"

She walks in wearing the red shimmer dress and takes him into her arms.

"This is all to celebrate your day."

Holding his hand, she leads him to the little tent and places a candle on the cake.

Make a wish.

"I wish that I get to spend all my birthdays with you."

Singing happy birthday together, they cut the cake and take a cute selfie.

"Happy birthday to you,

Happy birthday to you,

Happy birthday dear Gulinger,

Happy birthday to you..."

They settle into the tent with pizza and popcorn.

"Let's watch an action movie."

"No, Guls. Look at the surroundings. We should watch a romantic movie."

"How about a romantic action movie?"

"Okay, it's your day. Whatever you like."

The movie starts, but they spend almost as much time criticising it, talking about how this could never happen in reality. They dance when one of their favourite songs comes on and eventually get caught up in the emotional parts of the movie.

By the end of the night, the movie is over, the popcorn is half-finished and the cake is waiting for tomorrow. They stay in the little tent, curled up in each other's arms, talking until they fall asleep right there, wrapped around each other in the little world they had made together.





A Heartfelt Message from the Author



Thank you for reading till the end of our little story.

I hope this birthday brings you everything you deserve, happiness, good health, success, peace, and all the dreams you are still working towards.

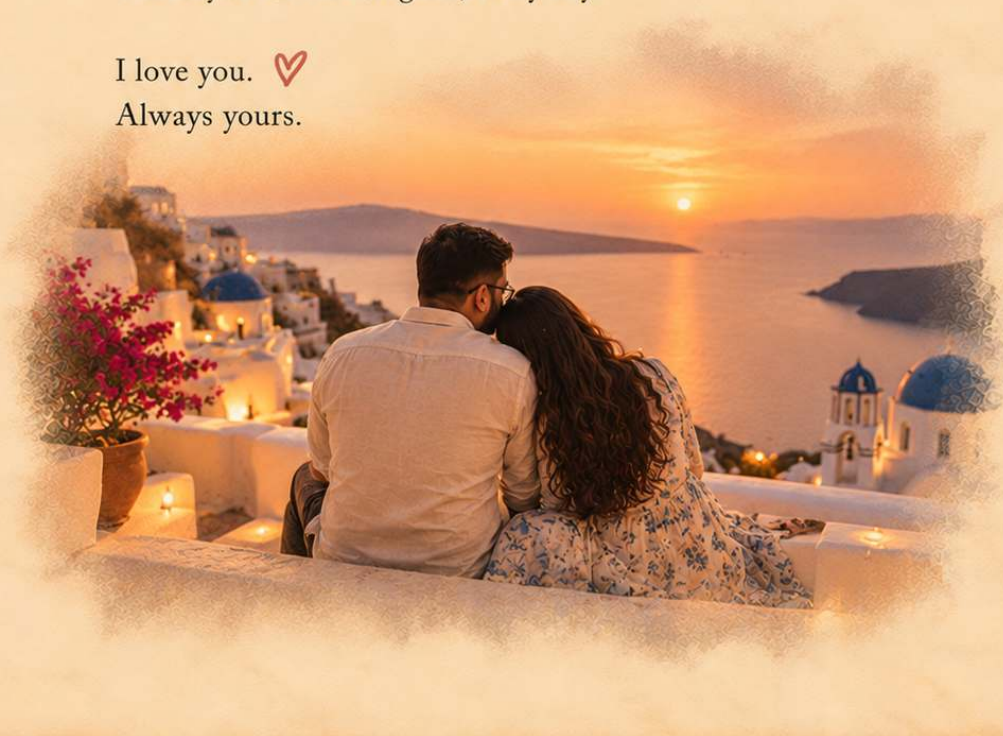
And I wish to be there for as many of these little moments as life gives us. I wish to spend all your next birthdays together, in person, where we can feel all the feelings together and not through a screen.

Thank you for finding me.

Thank you for choosing me, every day.

I love you. 

Always yours.



Some stories are written by chance.
Some feel as though they were waiting to be found.



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